



Sushi Ginza Onodera
Los Angeles



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Madai from Kyushu ・九州の真鯛

Hojiso and Myoga | 穂紫蘇と茗荷

Chawanmushi ・茶碗蒸し

Uni and Petrossian Caviar | 雲丹とキャビア

Buri from Hokkaido ・北海道の鰯

Mustard Sauce and Yuzu Zest | マスタードソースと柚子の皮

Tako no Yawarani ・蛸の柔煮

Yuzu Koshō | 柚子胡椒

Kegani ・毛蟹

Hojiso and Dashi | 穂紫蘇と出汁

Katsuo ・鰹

Deep Fried Shiso Leaf, Garlic Sauce, Garlic Chips, Myoga | 紫蘇、ニンニク、茗荷

Kinmedai ・金目鯛

Kinome, Horenso, and Shaved Dry Bonito | 木の芽、ほうれん草、鰹節

————— *NIGIRI* ・握り —————

Hirame ・平目 | Aomori ・青森県

Shiro Ebi ・白海老 | Toyama ・富山

Wild Maguro Akami ・野生の本マグロの赤身 | Aomori Tappi ・青森県竜飛

Aoyagi Kombujime ・青柳の昆布締め | Hokkaido ・北海道

Aburi Kamasu ・鰯の炙り

Kurumaebi ・車海老

Wild Maguro Chutoro ・野生の本マグロの中トロ | Aomori Tappi ・青森県竜飛

Bafun Uni ・馬糞うに | Hokkaido ・北海道

Akadashi ・赤だし味噌汁

Wild Maguro Otoro Hagashi ・野生の本マグロの大トロのはがし | Aomori Tappi ・青森県竜飛

Aburi Nodoguro ・喉黒の炙り | Nagasaki ・長崎

Anago with Sansho Pepper ・穴子と山椒

Temaki ・手巻き

Tamago ・玉子焼き

Coconut Blancmange with Matcha and Black Bean Kanroni

ココナッツのブラマンジェと抹茶と黒豆の甘露煮



A Japanese sushi Omakase experience, in contrast to a Western cuisine tasting menu, is markedly different. While Western restaurants operate with a complete brigade, delivering relatively consistent dishes to diners, the Omakase experience at a sushi counter is notably unpredictable. This unpredictability stems from various factors. On one hand, as I often emphasize, the state of the head chef is crucial because critical aspects of Omakase, such as the balance of sushi rice, fish cutting, and sushi preparation, depend solely on the skills of the head chef. Consequently, the overall stability of the meal is heavily influenced by the chef's proficiency. On the other hand, the ingredient selection process in sushi restaurants is highly unpredictable. For instance, at Sushi Noz in New York, after a demanding day, the head chef personally guides buyers over the phone to procure ingredients at the Toyosu market around midnight. The quality and variety of ingredients received can vary significantly each time. This underscores why Omakase, in this form, demands complete trust in the head chef—there is never a fixed menu. Even for widely available items like bluefin tuna, supplied almost year-round and presented in a sequence of akami, chutoro, and otoro cuts in almost every sushi restaurant, the grade, size, and whether it's wild-caught can fluctuate greatly, significantly influencing the tuna's taste at each restaurant.

Therefore, in the days preceding my visit to Ginza Onodera Los Angeles, I was fraught with anxiety, fervently hoping to be served a decent tuna. As I arrive at their doorstep and glimpse the tuna label on the counter, sheer joy sweeps over me. This is an extraordinary tuna, sourced by the eminent nakaoroshi 「仲卸店」 Yamayuki 「やま幸」, caught from Cape Tappi in Aomori Prefecture. Weighing in at 220kg, this wild tuna stands as the largest I have ever encountered. Yet, the most important element is the fishing method — Ipponzuri 「一本釣り」. The majority of tuna are caught using the Haenawa 「延縄」 method, a highly efficient but often impactful technique that leaves the fish in suboptimal condition upon initial capture. The delay in pulling in the net after capture will result in the tuna caught early in the process struggling underwater for a significant duration. Due to their larger size and greater strength compared to other fish, tuna experience a more pronounced buildup of lactic acid during these struggles. Moreover, the central body temperature of tuna rises rapidly, resulting in a phenomenon colloquially referred to as "burning." In milder cases, there is an increase in acidity in the meat, while more severe instances may lead to a change in meat color, rupture of blood vessels near the spine, and the infiltration of blood into muscle tissue, forming thrombus-like patches. On the contrary, Ipponzuri represents the optimal fishing method. Ipponzuri involves using small fishing boats, where each fisherman employs a single line and a single hook to individually catch tuna. This method, characterized by the traditional one-on-one confrontation between the fisherman and the tuna, is commonly employed in Oma of Aomori for capturing tuna. Considering that tuna are large fish, the Ipponzuri technique poses significant challenges to the fisherman's physical strength and determination, making it a time-consuming fishing method. Typically, utilizing Ipponzuri to catch tuna helps preserve the tuna in relatively good condition, minimizing bodily stress. It also facilitates timely bleeding of the fish and removal of internal organs, preserving the freshness of the fish meat.



The Omakase experience unfolds seamlessly with a showcase centered around Madai sashimi. Presented on a luxurious golden plate, the simple cuts of Madai, complemented by traditional elements like hojiso and myoga, epitomize culinary refinement. The Madai flesh unveils a delicate sweetness and refreshing umami, accentuated by its satisfyingly firm texture. The hojiso, a delicate blossom of shiso, imparts a subtle, sweeter, yet reminiscent aroma compared to the shiso leaf. Meanwhile, the myoga, with its refreshing and succulent profile, introduces a mild sharpness tinged with hints of sweetness. Both components harmonize flawlessly with the sashimi, elevating the freshness with layers of subtlety and herbal fragrance. This marks an exceptionally well-executed opening course, setting the tone for an exquisite dining experience.



Continuing the culinary journey, the spotlight falls on the restaurant's most iconic dish – a traditional chawanmushi adorned with Uni and Petrossian Caviar. Delicately presented in a petite chawan, this dish may be small in size, but it boasts an abundance of rich flavors. The egg custard, though minimalist in its ingredient selection, reveals a pristine and sophisticated umami. This delicate profile is further heightened by the oceanic allure of the caviar and the mellow creaminess of the uni. That being said, the pinnacle of flavor emerges from the heavenly dashi infused into the egg custard—a symphony of exceptional richness and complexity that creates a tsunami of umami, making this dish a truly sublime experience.

Transitioning from a versatile representation of all seasons in the first dish, the next course exclusively graces the winter omakase menu. Taking center stage is the illustrious buri fish, a winter delicacy and, arguably, the paramount offering during this seasonal culinary journey. Sourced from Hokkaido, the buri sashimi undergoes a meticulous soaking in a shoyu sauce tank before making its captivating appearance. The shoyu bath imbues the buri with a rich umami, offering a profound depth that impeccably complements the fish's own sumptuous unctuousness. It's worth noting that buri and hamachi are the same species, commonly known as yellowtail. However, while hamachi is available throughout the year, the matured yellowtail, referred to as buri, stands out as a winter treasure, accumulating a luscious amount of fat in its body during the colder months. Renowned for its exceptional quality, the Himi Kan-buri 「氷見寒鰯」, hailing from Himi, holds particular fame. Yet, today's offering, though sourced from a distance, does not pale in comparison, showcasing excellence in every aspect.





Tako and Awabi are two highly praised components in an authentic Edomae sushi Omakase experience, both embodying a similar texture and symbolizing the meticulous preparation and artistry of stewing, known as ni 「煮」 in Japanese. Today, lacking the highly anticipated awabi in its own liver sauce, we are presented with a decent cut of Tako. The preparation for Tako is notably labor-intensive, requiring a massage lasting at least forty minutes. Subsequently, the Tako undergoes a deliberate stewing process known as Yawara-ni 「柔煮」, or occasionally a more intricate method called Sakura-ni 「桜煮」. The allure of Tako Yawara-ni lies in its uniquely delightful combination of an exceptionally tender yet somewhat rubbery texture, accompanied by an enticing and sophisticated aroma and a deep sweet-umami taste that unfolds while chewing. Notably, this sweetness is derived from the presence of glycine and betaine.

After the intense and profound Tako course, the subsequent course featuring Kegani with its own dashi and hojiso seems to lack vitality and depth. Supposed to be a signature dish at Ginza Onodera Los Angeles, this Kegani dish leaves one feeling somewhat disappointed. Its most fatal flaw is the absence of the expected core of ultimate sweetness and umami that makes the crab famous. A properly cooked Kegani should exude an extreme sweetness and profound umami that surpasses what other ingredients can offer, but perhaps due to a lack of quality or precise cooking time control, this crab fails to showcase the delectability it should inherently possess. Without the support of the umami, the caviar simply seems to be pointless here.







Fabulous tea-ware for hot green tea service



After the tsunami of bold richness comes the last otsumami dish, breezing in a sense of serenity before the showtime for nigiri. A cooked kinmedai takes center stage, shining with a golden hue in the modest blue atmosphere. The kinmedai perches on a pile of poached spinach, adorned with shaved dry bonito and kinome, an aromatic herb of Japanese sansho pepper. The essence of the dish lies in the beautiful interplay of the kinmedai flavor and the warm mellowness and calm pureness that the base dashi bestowed upon it. Blended with shoyu, sake, and mirin, the dashi uses shoyu again but in a drastically different manner, blending in a harmony of tranquility and depth of flavors.

A sophisticated Katsuo dish follows the crab delicacy, bringing back the depth and richness of shoyu. The strong flavor profile can already be anticipated as we witness the transition from the glass bowl of crab dish to a black-and-silver-themed plate reminiscent of Japanese Samurai armor. The black lacquer and the patterned silver interior not only please us aesthetically and echo the color of the katsuo, but they also foreshadow the bold and robust umami, inviting us to anticipate its rich culinary experience. In this exquisite presentation, a fine cut of katsuo lays on top of a shallow pond of glossy garlic shoyu sauce. The fish is garnished with delicate deep-fried shiso leaf, crispy garlic chips, and refreshing myoga. It's a daring departure for an Edomae sushi chef to embrace garlic so boldly, but the decision pays off handsomely. The garlic, presented either as an infuser in the sauce or as crispy chips, imparts intoxicating aromas and adds a satisfying texture to the medley. Notwithstanding, the katsuo's innate, distinctive flavor shines through, standing tall amidst the opulence of its accompaniments, ensuring its essence remains undimmed.





Ensuing the presentation of the kinmedai dish of warmth and depth comes the eagerly awaited nigiri session. While most people look forward to high-quality seafood in nigiri, what I value the most is the shari, or sushi rice. It serves as the foundation for a perfect piece of nigiri. A flawless shari ball should be incredibly airy, almost like a cloud gently landing on the sushi plate. Notably, a perfect nigiri sushi piece will arrive on the plate with a soft landing that causes it to sink slightly. Simultaneously, each grain of rice should possess a fine texture and resilience—neither excessively moist, making it prone to falling apart, nor overly dry, leading to an unpleasant mouthfeel.

Ginza Onodera Los Angeles uses a blend of 30% Yumepirika rice from Hokkaido and 70% Koshihikari rice from Miyagi for its shari. Among all the rice varieties, yumepirika, the local subkind of Hokkaido, is undoubtedly the softest and stickiest one. Such an incredibly soft texture requires a firmer counterpart, which explains the presentation of koshihikari rice, a much firmer yet similarly highly sticky rice variety.



The feast of nigiri unfolds, starting on the preparation of gari, also known as sushi ginger. While it is not much as showy as the New York Ginza Onodera's chef would do it with a long samurai sword, it is still an utmost joy to taste ginger at such tenderness and juiciness, with just about the right spiciness. The nigiri that follows, unfortunately, pales in comparison, and such disappointment starts with the hiramasa from Aomori and the shiro-ebi from Toyama. With such a mild and delicate flavor, the hiramasa cut into such thinness is easily overshadowed by the shari, not to mention when the shari in the first few pieces is extremely dry. The almost hard texture of each piece of rice stabs like a sharp dagger, displeasing the palate while completely destroying the texture of the hiramasa. The shiro-ebi, a naturally sweet delicate shrimp, also suffers from the bullying of the dry shari, causing a total loss of its subtlety. The improper shari moisture is a shame in such a esteemed property, and more importantly, a huge affront to the meticulous mix of yumepirika and koshihikari.



Unlike most sushi omakase restaurants that presents three selections of tuna continuously, Ginza Onodera Los Angeles chooses to place akami, chutoro, and otoro across the whole nigiri session, functions like three refrains in a rondeau. With such a high-profile tuna, our expectations have soared to new heights. Yet, it is this very expectation that has magnified the disappointment stemming from the gap between our ideal and the stark reality before us.

It must be acknowledged that the tuna has been housed for several days, possibly past its peak condition. However, it falls upon the chef to ensure that the quality remains exceptional. If the chef has chosen to serve the tuna in its current state, it is a testament to his approval of its quality. In such a case, any issues with the dish lie either in its preparation or in the chef's judgment. Being a wild-caught tuna, it is expected to be relatively lean. While many favor the extravagantly fatty otoro, it is the leaner parts that truly showcase the pristine flavor of tuna. Thus, even with its fattiest sections, a wild-caught tuna embodies the essence of tuna remarkably well.



For the first akami nigiri, the persistent dryness of the shari remains a thorn in the side. However, the vital concern is the quality of the flesh itself. The meat is somewhat lacking in flavor and cohesion. Such a tuna should ideally exhibit a relaxed yet not loose texture due to the aging process. The current sloppiness, however, suggests a decay of its quality rather than a natural result of dry aging. When the next sushi shows up as a gunkan-zushi instead of the chutoro, I am immediately aware that the nervousness for tuna is going to carry through the omakase experience. Regrettably, the gunkan-zushi does not help much to ease my nerves. The Aoyagi from Hokkaido went through a marinating process called Kombujime and then placed gently into a gunkan-zushi. The kombujime process fails to offer much algae taste but is mainly just a touch of brininess, and the Aoyagi themselves lack sweetness. That being said, the most unpleasant aspect sources from the nori wrapping the gunkan-zushi. A decent procedure is to place the nori on a shichirin grill to make it extra dry and crispy. Unfortunately, the chef chooses to neglect this important procedure, resulting in a somewhat unpleasant mushy nori texture.





Following the Aoyagi is the kamasu, a highly valued fish for sushi chefs renowned for its unique flavor and texture. While the visual presentation of the flesh is not ideal, the aburi process fortunately imparts a mesmerizing smoky tone to the fish, further sublimating its umami. The kamasu's flesh has an exceptionally high water content, and it becomes even more tender and almost fluffy after the aburi process. Another positive note is that the chef changed the shari at this point, resulting in a more moisturized texture that provides a crucial foundation for the nigiri that follows.

With an addition of 35 dollars, we ordered one kurumaebi to share. Kurumaebi, unlike the shiro ebi we just sampled, is notably larger in size and is typically served cooked. After undergoing a steaming spa, the raw shrimp transforms into a pleasingly red color and develops a sweet taste and firm texture, becoming such a delightful bite for the discerning palate. If I were to be meticulous, a more refined cooking time can help to achieve a bouncier texture.

Just as a skilled Japanese sushi chef would age tuna and marinate Shiromi fish in kombu, they also pay meticulous attention to the pickles, which is sometimes presented as part of an omakase experience and serves a function similar to gari ginger. Some chefs value their marinade—often a specially formulated shoyu—so highly that they carry it with them to different places and age it for years. While I have often tasted shoyu-marinated daikon, here at Ginza Onodera Los Angeles, something unique is presented. On a small plate, we find pickled eggplant and kakana, a leafy yasai similar to mustard greens.

After the quasi-intermission, the return of tuna brings us back on track. With a much better knife work, a beautiful piece of chutoro nigiri perches on the sushi plate, alluring me to degust the flesh once more. With the help of the remedied shari, we are able to fully engulf the palate in the tasting of the tuna. Though still not ideally textured, the chutoro is more flavored, showcasing an equilibrium of fattiness and leanness. The slightly higher fatty content stimulates the umami of the tuna while providing a rounded texture as foundation for the umami to fully shine through.





If caviar holds the supreme position in Western cuisine due to its high compatibility and exorbitant price, then uni must be its counterpart in Japanese cuisine. Uni, with its relatively high price, heavenly creamy texture, and tropical fruity taste, has captured the hearts of countless epicureans, and it boasts the same high level of compatibility. Whether enjoyed alone, made into nigiri, maki, or gunkan-zushi, or mixed with rice and served alongside grilled nodoguro. Whether used as a sauce to accompany Shiromi fish sashimi or presented on top of nori tempura like a nouvelle burger. These trendy dishes seem to be indispensable choices in contemporary Japanese sushi restaurants.



The supply of premium uni seems to have greatly increased in recent years, with many restaurants even hosting astonishing horizontal tastings of more than a dozen different brands. Chefs are competing to acquire auction-grade SP Murasaki uni from brands like Hadate 「羽立」 or Higashizawa 「東沢」. Even for Bafun uni that are not auctioned, premium brands like Ogawa 「小川」 or Kaneyo Dai Gokujou 「カネヨ 鵜洋水産の大極上」 are highly sought after by chefs. As familiarity with premium uni grows, another type of uni that was once overlooked seems to be gaining prominence. Even top brands like Hadate or Higashizawa must add alum to maintain the shape and freshness of uni. However, there is a type of uni sold in saltwater that is gaining popularity in the market due to its additive-free nature. Now, we are about to taste the saltwater Bafun uni without alum. In front of us, the box cracks open and the chef scoops out the fresh uni from saltwater, then gently places it in a clear water bowl to remove excess salinity. The uni is then shaped into non-traditional sushi style and presented in separate exquisite dishes. Unlike those bursting with rich tropical mango flavors, this batch of uni offers a more refreshing and elegant sensation. Initially, a gentle oceanic brininess bursts out, followed by a subtle sweetness seeping from the uni, saturating the palate with refreshing lusciousness.



The presentation of the otoro signals the crescendo of the omakase experience towards its climax. The chef explains that the otoro has been meticulously processed using the Hagashi method, a labor-intensive technique that removes all sinews and tendons. However, to my disappointment, some sinews are not only visible but also noticeable in the mouth, significantly diminishing the pleasure of indulging in a sinew-free otoro that should ideally melt on the tongue. Despite this, the umami of the otoro is outstanding. This particular cut, specifically a jabara otoro cut, owing to the wild-caught nature of the fish, is relatively lean, yet its umami is remarkably profound.





Presented alongside the Otoro is a cup of Akadashi, which differs from the typical miso soup or shirodashi. Akadashi, literally meaning red soup, is a miso soup with a deeper, more intense flavor profile. Following this, we have the final two pieces of nigiri.

First is the nodoguro from Nagasaki. The nodoguro I have previously tasted was presented grilled and served with uni and rice, its rich fattiness irresistibly enticing. Now, this nodoguro is served as nigiri, still grilled to perfection, maintaining the fish's aromatic unctuousness. The last piece, a customary finale in all sushi restaurants, is a sweet Anago nigiri. Anago is a delicacy that no one can resist. Here, the chef adds a touch of sansho seasoning, enhancing the deep sweetness with a hint of tongue-tingling numbness, a delightful surprise to end the nigiri session.

With another additional 65 dollars, we indulge in a luxurious off-menu Temaki. Temaki hand roll is not a traditional Japanese sushi roll but a fast-food item invented under the influence of fast-food culture. Interestingly and ironically, in traditional Japanese restaurants in this fast-food nation, adding such a non-traditional Japanese hand roll, which is closer to American dietary habits, seems quite fitting. The filling of this hand roll also reflects the California and Hollywood style, opting for a lavish stack of expensive ingredients. Inside this roll, there is not only the exquisite combination of caviar and uni but also tuna, pickled daikon, shiso, and a round squid similar to sumi ika called mongo ika. Unfortunately, this combination does not bring about an exceptional experience but rather an unsuccessful experiment. Although the practice of piling up luxurious ingredients is often scorned by many chefs and professional foodies, certain clever combinations can still make this luxurious hand roll shine. Similarly using ika, uni, and tuna, the experience at Manshu Kaiseki surprisingly outshines this one.





As an unavoidable hurdle for sushi restaurants, the long-awaited tamagoyaki arrives as expected. Just like shari, the quality of tamagoyaki is a genuine testament to a chef's expertise. Similar to how a traditional French chef's mastery is often judged by the perfection of an omelette, seemingly simple egg cuisine demands remarkable finesse. Traditional tamagoyaki always includes shrimp, and this rendition features the very same kurumaebi we relished moments ago. Furthermore, yam is artfully blended into the tamagoyaki, yielding a velvety, moist castella cake imbued with an exquisitely rich egg essence that lingers on the palate. In contrast to Nozawa's penchant for elaborate additions, this traditional approach eloquently showcases the chef's artistry and promises the most enduring delight for diners.



The final dessert, as anticipated, is the Coconut Blancmange, delicately topped with rich matcha juice and a kanroni black bean. This dessert seems to be the pièce de résistance at Ginza Onodera worldwide, as it was the very same one I savored four years ago at Ginza Onodera New York. Unlike Panna Cotta, the Coconut Blancmange is set not with gelatin but with cornstarch, making it seemingly lighter. The intense coconut flavor, combined with the creaminess from the milk, is a classic dessert that never disappoints. The layer of matcha on top, almost condensed like a koicha rather than usucha, brings a zen aroma of roasted nuts. Neither bitter nor unpleasantly astringent, but rather a subtle and pleasant restraint mouthfeel, bringing an indescribable perfect balance to the whole. The kanroni black bean on top is the crowning touch to the medley, slowly stewed in sugar with a touch of soy sauce, creating a glossy and mirror-like surface. It not only adds a visual touch to the overall presentation but also provides the final elevation to the taste and texture, culminating in a sublime finish.

